

GROUND WIT. - ATCONTROLLER

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**National UFO Reporting Center
Air Traffic Controller Testimony
February 20, 1997**

NUFORC Index

The following letter was received from a California air traffic controller whose name has been withheld by request.

Dear Sirs:

I've been an air traffic controller at the Los Angeles Air Route Traffic Control Center for six years now, with my area of jurisdiction covering northeast of LAX, out over the Mohave desert (including the Edwards test ranges), and up around the LAS area (including "Dreamland"). We work closely with the military, and when I am at a sector, there is NOTHING that goes in my sky (military or civilian) without my knowledge. Even the most classified military projects have proper protocol for reservation of airspace, and numerous flight restrictions (they're not about to let their multi-billion dollar projects be sighted or be harmed by some Dentist's Cessna 172 chugging along for a weekend trip to Vegas, after all). Projects are of course need-to-know, but they'll just call them something else to keep with procedures and restrictions (the Stealth fighter went around as an "A6" fighter when it was classified).

The point is, we know ---*I* know, when I'm at the sector--- all military activity, and all civilian aircraft certainly above 18,000 feet (federal regulations prohibit flight above Flight level 180 without authorization from the controller), and most activity below 18,000.

In my (only) six years at the Center, I have personally been part of three bizarre encounters, non-military and non-civilian. I'm just one of 15,000 controllers, too, so there *have* to be many more that go unreported. I know we used to have a specific number to report "UFO" sightings (was it to your organization?), but in the late 80's the directive was replaced by an official "advisory" to tell pilots, if requested, that they should contact a University or research institution, and no further paperwork was required (unless it was a near mid-air).

| quote re. contact

In a fourth incident I was present for (in the area but not at the actual sector), the controller told the supe about the encounter, and after both determined there was nothing on radar, they just kind of shook their heads and rubbed their chins, and that was that. This I believe is what typically happens. Nobody knows what to do, really. There is no government "coverup," no mirror-sunglassed agents "debriefing" us in the back room, no military specialists to take reports. But "UFO" encounters happen...I've directly been involved in those three incidents---DIRECT involvement, I was there plugged into the sector, my own eyes were watching the radar, it actually happened! I've been puzzled on all three, but there was no place to report it, no official literature on what to do about it, until I saw your organization.

So, thanks for your efforts---I've got your number now and will certainly contact you at my next "incidents" so you can get the hard data (voice tapes are erased after 15 days, and radar data after 5 I believe).